Sripada Ramanujacharya

Ramanujacharya · @ramanujacharya

The Acharya of the Sri Sampradaya

Ramanujacharya is the founder-acharya of the Sri sampradaya, the Vaishnava line that traces its origin to Lakshmi (Sri), the eternal consort of Vishnu. It is one of the four recognized sampradayas — the Brahma, Sri, Rudra and Kumara sampradayas; the Gaudiya Vaishnavas descend in the line of Brahma. The four sampradayas of Kali-yuga — those of Sri, Brahma, Rudra and Sanaka — are named in a verse of the “Padma Purana” cited in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (21), and Ramanuja acknowledged Lakshmi as the original guru of his line. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.2110–2119) says: “Sri” is Lakshmi, the beloved and the disciple of Narayana; in her line Ramanujacharya appeared, and from him the Ramanuja sampradaya began. His earlier name was Sri Lakshmanacharya, and all came to call him Ramanujacharya out of great reverence; he composed a bhashya named after himself, and the branches of his line covered the whole world. The “Anuragavalli” (8.39) adds that he refuted the paths of knowledge and karma and established the truth of bhakti, and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta calls Lakshmi, whom Ramanujacharya, the teacher of vishishtadvaita, worships, the original guru of the Sri sampradaya.

His teaching is called vishishtadvaita-vada — the doctrine of oneness qualified by distinctions. His interpretation of the Vedanta rivals Shankara's, especially in the Tamil South, where Sri Vaishnavism remains strong to this day; and the “Sri-bhashya” is the best-known Vaishnava commentary on the Vedanta and still the strongest challenge to Shankara's commentary. Besides it Ramanuja left an explanation of the “Bhagavad-gita,” the “Vedanta-sara” and the “Vedartha-sangraha,” a digest of the essentials of the Vedas. His life and teaching are known in detail: soon after his departure biographies were composed — the Sanskrit “Prapannamrita” of Anantacharya and others in Tamil.

Long before Ramanuja the Alvars, the “divine sages” (divya-suris), had appeared in the South. Within the Sri sampradaya itself his predecessors were Nathamuni and his grandson Yamunacharya, Ramanuja's direct spiritual forerunner.

Birth and Family

A verse dedicated to him says:

“I worship Ramanuja, the form of Shesha, born in Tundira-mandala in Chaitra under the star Ardra, who came to establish the teaching of Vishnu.”

According to Sri Vaishnava tradition this was in 1017; in our calendar his appearance day is Gaura-panchami of the month of Vishnu. His father was the pious brahmana Asuri Keshavacharya of Sriperumbudur, a place about 26 miles out of Madras. His mother, Bhudevi, was a sister of Periya Tirumalai Nambi (Sri Shaila Purna), the beloved disciple of Yamunacharya; another sister was named Sridevi — both were named after the two consorts of Sri Venkateshvara.

The name Lakshmana was given to the boy by his uncle Nambi, in honour of Ramachandra's brother. Sri Vaishnavas revere Ramanuja as an incarnation of Lakshmana himself; and since Lakshmana is the great servant of Rama, he came to be called Rama-anuja, “the one who follows Rama.”

The family belonged to the Vadama Smarta brahmanas, learned in the Vedas. The father zealously performed Vedic sacrifices and bore the epithet Sarvakratu, “one who has performed all sacrifices.” He himself instructed his son in grammar, logic and Vedic learning. The boy did not yet know the Tamil hymns in praise of Vishnu, but devotion awoke in him through his association with Kanchipurna, a

disciple of Yamunacharya who was not a brahmana by birth. The saintliness of his nature was evident from early childhood. He passed through all the samskaras, including the upanayana, and married at sixteen. Only a month later his father fell gravely ill and died.

With Yadava Prakasha

After his father's death the family moved to Kanchipuram, and Ramanuja entered the school of Yadava Prakasha, an impersonalist Vedantist of Shankara's school. Some see in this a sign that the family was not strictly Vaishnava; others hold that he deliberately studied Shankara's arguments in order to refute them later.

Ramanuja became a favourite pupil, but the doctrine that every form, even the form of Vishnu, is illusory was repugnant to him; yet, revering his teacher, he kept from dispute. One day, as he was massaging his teacher's back, Yadava Prakasha, following Shankara, explained the words of the "Chandogya Upanishad" (1.6.7), "kapyāsaṁ puṇḍarīkam evam akṣiṇī," as though the eyes of Vishnu were compared to a monkey's hindquarters. Hot tears from Ramanuja fell on his back. Ramanuja proposed another interpretation: "kapyasam" is that which rests on the water and lives by drinking it — that is, the lotus; the eyes of Vishnu are beautiful as a crimson lotus.

Yadava Prakasha saw a rival in him and with his disciples plotted to kill him in a deserted place on the road to the Ganga, and then to bathe in the Ganga to wash away the sin. A cousin warned Ramanuja, and he escaped. Back in Kanchi, Yadava Prakasha resumed his lectures, and Ramanuja attended them, though he was already seeking another path.

Yamunacharya himself came to Kanchi to see the young man. Seeing that he was still studying under Yadava Prakasha, he did not approach him; it is said that he prayed from afar that Ramanuja would become the establisher of the teaching (darshana-pravartaka) of the Sri sampradaya.

In Kanchi a brahma-rakshasa took hold of the king's daughter. He merely mocked Yadava Prakasha, but begged Ramanuja for dust from his feet and left the princess; from then on the king felt indebted to Ramanuja.

In the end Yadava Prakasha told him to leave the ashrama. The final break came over the interpretation of the words "sarvaṁ khalv idaṁ brahma" ("Chandogya Upanishad" 3.14.1) and "neha nānāsti kiñcana" ("Katha Upanishad" 4.11). Ramanuja explained: the world is not Brahman, but is pervaded by Him, comes forth from Him, is sustained by Him and enters into Him, as a fish lives in water while remaining distinct from the water. "There is no difference" means that all is bound together like pearls on a single thread, yet each pearl keeps its own qualities. What is meant, then, is not absolute identity, but oneness marked by distinct qualities.

Kanchipurna and Yamunacharya

On his mother's advice Ramanuja accepted the guidance of Kanchipurna. Kanchipurna told him to carry water for the Deity of Vishnu in Lord Varada's temple. Ramanuja served Kanchipurna, who then took him as a disciple; that his teacher was a shudra by birth and he himself a brahmana did not lessen his devotion in the least. But his wife could not bear it.

Meanwhile the aged Yamunacharya, already dying, heard that Ramanuja had left Yadava Prakasha and was serving Kanchipurna, and sent his disciples to fetch him. Ramanuja hastened to Srirangam, but found that the teacher had already departed for Vaikuntha. Three fingers of Yamunacharya's right hand were clenched — unusually, as his disciples remarked. Ramanuja understood that these were three unfulfilled wishes, and made three vows. He vowed to teach ordinary people to surrender to Vishnu through the five purificatory rites (pancha-samskara) — and one finger opened. He vowed to explain the

Alvars' hymns in a commentary — the second opened. He promised to write a commentary on the Vedanta-sutras establishing Sri Vaishnavism as the highest conclusion of the Vedas — the third opened, and the teacher's face shone with peace. Thenceforth the biography calls Yamunacharya Ramanuja's divine teacher.[1]

Sannyasa

Back in Kanchi, Ramanuja devoted himself to serving Kanchipurna and the temple and grew cold towards home, while his wife suffered that he neglected her for a “low-born” man. Once he invited Kanchipurna to a meal so as to partake of his remnants. Kanchipurna came early, and the wife (the biography calls her Kambalaksha) hastily fed the guest, removed his banana leaf with a stick, had the room washed and bathed herself. Learning of this offence to his guru, Ramanuja was angered. And when at the well her water accidentally mingled with that of Kanchipurna's wife and she cursed the other woman as “untouchable,” Ramanuja sent her back to her parents and left to take sannyasa.

In the temple of Varadaraja, before the Deity he had long served, he accepted the saffron cloth and the tridanda of a Vaishnava sannyasi — three staffs signifying that mind, body and speech are given to Vishnu. From then on he was called Yati-raja, “king of renunciants.” The tridandis of his line bear the title “Ramanujarya-svami”; the single staff of Shankara's followers the Sri Vaishnavas do not accept. Nisikanta Sanyal (“Sree Krishna Chaitanya,” 1933, with a foreword by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta) adds that Lakshmana accepted sannyasa on the bank of the Anantasaras, the temple tank at Kanchi, invoking the grace of Sri Yamunacharya, and soon became the head of the Sri-sampradaya.

Disciples in Kanchi

Ramanuja established an ashrama by the temple in Kanchi and began to teach Vedanta and bhakti. The first to become his disciple was his nephew, his elder sister's son, Mudali Andan (Dasharathi); the second was the learned and wealthy brahmana Kuresha (Kurattalvar), famed for his memory.

Yadava Prakasha's mother, devoted to Vishnu, grieved over her son's monism and persuaded him to visit Ramanuja; in a dream a voice told him to become Ramanuja's disciple. Next morning he asked whether there was any basis in scripture for the Vaishnava marks and dress. At Ramanuja's sign Kuresha cited verses of shruti — from the “Rig Veda” (Bashkala shakha), the “Atharva Veda” and the “Vayaviya Upapurana” — on the marks of conch, disc, lotus and club and on the tilaka (urdhva-pundra); on the qualities of Brahman — from the “Mundaka Upanishad” (“He who is all-knowing and knows everything”) and the “Shvetashvatara Upanishad” (6.8): “He has no work to do and no instruments of action… His supreme energy is heard to be manifold” — manifesting as knowledge, strength and action; on Narayana and Hari as the Supreme — “Narayana is the supreme Brahman” (“Taittiriya Narayana Upanishad”) and “Hari is the supreme refuge” (“Hari-bhakti-sudhodaya” 3.52). These verses, according to one biography, are cited by Vedanta Deshika in the “Sach-charitra-raksha.”

Yadava Prakasha fell at Ramanuja's feet and became his disciple under the name Govinda Jiyar. He took sannyasa, served the cause of Sri Vaishnavism and at Ramanuja's bidding wrote for the sannyasis of his line the “Yati-dharma-samucchaya,” which is followed to this day.

Srirangam

The disciples of Yamunacharya at Srirangam begged Ramanuja to lead them, and, having received leave from the Deity Varada, he moved from Kanchi to Srirangam. There he studied the scriptures under Mahapurna, a prominent disciple of Yamunacharya: the “Nyaya-tattva,” the “Gitartha-sangraha,” the “Siddhi-traya,” the Brahma-sutras and the Pancharatras.

On Mahapurna's advice he asked Goshthipurna for the mantra. Goshthipurna refused him eighteen times, and only at last, seeing his tears, gave him the mantra, making him swear to reveal it to no one: whoever chants it will attain liberation and service in Vaikuntha. This patience and resolve of the disciple are remembered in our own time as well: just as persistently Srila Bhaktisiddhanta begged initiation from Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji.

Coming out of the temple, Ramanuja addressed the assembled people: “Chant: oṁ namo nārāyaṇāya!” Goshthipurna demanded an explanation, and Ramanuja answered that he would gladly go to hell for his disobedience, if only the people might be saved. Moved, Goshthipurna fell at his feet: “You are my teacher; take me as your disciple.” By breaking the letter of the instruction, Ramanuja grasped its spirit: there is no law higher than giving away the Lord's mercy.

Preaching

His fame spread everywhere; he was honoured as an incarnation of Lakshmana, and with vishishtadvaita he defeated scholars. The pandita Yajnamurti challenged him to debate on condition that the loser would carry the victor's sandals and become his disciple; Ramanuja, in case of defeat, promised to give up books and debate. The debate lasted seventeen days. Ramanuja prayed to Varada, and in a dream the Deity promised him victory and told him to follow the arguments of Yamunacharya. Next morning Yajnamurti himself conceded defeat and became his disciple.

With his disciples Ramanuja toured India; in the north, in Kashmir, he consulted Bodhayana's commentary on the Vedanta-sutras. Wherever he went he set Deity worship in order, removing customs foreign to Vaishnavas, and introduced a uniform order of service in Vaishnava temples.

In Jagannatha Puri, where worship follows the path of spontaneous love (raga-marga), his reforms were received without enthusiasm. It is said that Lord Jagannatha was displeased and one night carried the sleeping Ramanuja to Kurmasthana (Srikurmam). On waking, Ramanuja thought he had greatly offended Vishnu: he took the Deity of Kurma for a Shiva-linga and believed that Vishnu had cast him into a temple of Shiva;[2] but on learning that this was Kurma, an avatara of Vishnu, he set the worship there in order. This was in the eleventh Shaka century; later the temple of Srikurmam came under the supervision of a Madhva math in the domains of Vijayanagara.

It was then that Ramanuja wrote the “Sri-bhashya,” and his fame grew still greater.

The Chola king, a zealous Shaivite, demanded that scholars sign a statement that Shiva is supreme, and when Ramanuja refused, he resolved to seize him. Kuresha exchanged clothes with his teacher: Ramanuja escaped in the guise of a householder, while Kuresha, in a sannyasi's robes, was arrested. He refused to glorify Shiva; remembering the healing of his daughter, the king did not execute him, but had him blinded. Later Kuresha's sight was miraculously restored, while the king died of a black abscess on his neck and was remembered as “Krimi-kantha,” “worm-throat.”

Ramanuja converted many thousands and founded many temples. He passed through the lands of present-day Madurai and Mysore, converting Jains; according to tradition, he once defeated a thousand Jains, who chose to take their own lives rather than become Vaishnavas. Known too is his secluded bhajana at Tirunarayanapura: many centuries later Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura advised Srila Bhaktisiddhanta to withdraw likewise for bhajana in Mayapur.

He was merciful to householders as well. Dhanurdasa, bound by attachment to his lovely wife, he led into Narayana's temple and showed him the beauty of the Deity, which eclipses all worldly beauty — and from then on Dhanurdasa was a devotee of rare depth.

Once he gave his disciples a lesson in detachment. First he told one of them to mix up the clothes of some sannyasis who were bathing — and the learned renunciants quarrelled over rags. Then, having seen to it that Dhanurdasa was busy with service in the temple, he sent the same disciple to his house one evening to take the jewellery off his sleeping wife. She turned over so that the rest could be taken as well, but the frightened disciple fled. When her husband came home she told him that the holy men of the temple must be in want of money to resort to such a thing. Dhanurdasa reproached her: had she been free of false ego she would have given everything, and instead she had only scared him away; and she agreed that pride alone had kept her from giving all. Ramanuja explained to the disciple the meaning of both incidents: renunciants may be attached to rags, while householders may be free of possessions and glad to give them up for service.

He taught by word and by example, and his influence is felt to this day.

Departure and Successors

According to tradition, Ramanuja lived a hundred years. In our calendar the day of his departure is Gaura-dashami of the month of Madhava.[3] His parampara still preserves the customs of Sri Vaishnava life he established, the order of Deity worship and his philosophy. From his disciple Kuresha the line passed to Kuresha's younger son Ram-pillai, then to Vagvijaya Bhatta and to his son Vedavyasa Bhatta, or Sudarshanacharya; the service of Ranganatha at Srirangam was directed by Yamunacharya, Ramanuja, Sudarshanacharya and others. The next great acharya of the line after Ramanuja was Vedanta Deshika.

The general shape of Sri Vaishnavism had been outlined already by Yamunacharya; it fell to Ramanuja to fill it out in detail, to establish it in the mind of the South as an orthodox sampradaya and to give it a place in history.

Ramanuja and the Gaudiya Vaishnavas

Together with Madhva, Vishnusvami, Nimbarka and Sri Chaitanya, Ramanuja fought Shankara's mayavada. Madhva himself, on visiting Srirangam, found vishishtadvaita not firm enough against Shankara. Srila Jiva Gosvami in the “Sarva-samvadini” counts Ramanuja and Madhva among the upholders of the doctrine of difference (bheda). Examining four kinds of teaching on bhakti, he notes that for Ramanuja the sole reality is Ishvara, qualified by two attributes, chit and achit, the conscious and the unconscious. Sri Chaitanya completed Ramanuja's teaching on the Lord's energy by revealing the perfect doctrine of achintya-bheda-abheda.

The family of Gopala Bhatta Gosvami — Venkata, Trimalla and Prabodhananda — were Sri Vaishnavas of Ramanuja's line, of the Vadagalai branch; Prabodhananda was a tridandi of this line who had come to Srirangam from Mysore. Venkata, raised in this sampradaya, turned to Gaudiya Vaishnavism when the Lord spent the chaturmasya with him; Prabodhananda, who had earlier followed vishishtadvaita, accepted Mahaprabhu's achintya-bheda-abheda. Gopala Bhatta saw in the South the virtuous way of life (sadachara) of Ramanuja's Vaishnavas and compiled the “Sat-kriya-sara-dipika” taking his views into account; a manuscript from Sanketa bows to Ramanujacharya among the acharyas of the four sampradayas.

Mahaprabhu Himself, coming to the South, kept the chaturmasya in Sri Ranga-kshetra, the abode of Sri Vaishnavas strict in their practice: Srila Bhaktisiddhanta writes that at that time only Sri Vaishnavas lived there, and the Lord judged it the most favourable place for His vow. Every day He bathed in the Kaveri and sang and danced before Sri Ranganatha, and all the brahmana Vaishnavas of Ranga-kshetra vied to invite Him. Venkata Bhatta, after the custom of the Sri Vaishnavas, served Lakshmi-Narayana, and the Lord, having become his friend, playfully asked why Lakshmi, the most chaste of wives, longs

for the company of the cowherd boy Krishna and yet cannot enter His rasa-lila, while the personified Shrutis, following the gopis, attained Him. Venkata held Narayana to be Svayam Bhagavan Himself and the worship of the Sri Vaishnavas to be the highest; this pride the Lord broke in jest: Svayam Bhagavan is Krishna, Narayana is His vilasa, and Krishna is attained only in the footsteps of the people of Vraja and the gopis. Then He consoled him with words on which the faith of all Vaishnavas rests: “The divine nature of Krishna and Narayana is identical. In the same way there is no difference between the gopis of Vraja and the goddess Lakshmi”; “The goddess Lakshmi tastes the sweetness of Krishna's company through the gopis of Vraja. All the eternal forms of the Supreme are of one nature. To see any difference between the Avataras of God is an offence” (CC, Madhya 9.153, 9.155). Venkata accepted this and said that his very meeting with the Lord was the mercy of Lakshmi-Narayana in answer to his service, and that the highest goal is Krishna-bhakti. Thus the brothers, worshippers of Lakshmi-Narayana, by the Lord's mercy came to relish Krishna-rasa. In the brief list of the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” the Lord's host is named Trimalla Bhatta, “of the Sri Vaishnava community”; it also says that the Vaishnavas of the South then worshipped Rama, some being Tattvavadis and some Sri Vaishnavas, and that after meeting the Lord all became devotees of Krishna (Madhya 1.107–110, 9.11–12).

Srila Jiva Gosvami says in the “Tattva-sandarbha” that he consulted Madhva, Shridhara Svami and Ramanujacharya, and in the supplementary commentary on it he examines the teachings of Madhva and Ramanuja. The Gosvamis in general quoted Ramanuja, Madhva and Shridhara alike. Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura called Jiva a pandita and a master of the Vedanta equal to Ramanuja. When at Galta near Jaipur opponents[4] challenged the standing of the Gaudiyas, who had no commentary of their own on the Vedanta, Baladeva Vidyabhushana defeated them. According to one biography, the panditas then recognized Baladeva as an acharya and wished to become his disciples, but he humbly declined: of the four sampradayas the Sri sampradaya is a genuine school, preaching service to God as the highest path, and in upholding the Gaudiya teaching he wished to show it not the least disrespect, for to offend it would be a grave offence.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati said that having many disciples, as Madhva and Ramanuja had, is no hindrance at all on the path of sadhana. In 1896 Srila Bhaktivinoda wrote the “Sri-Ramanuja-upadesha” in Bengali. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta studied Ramanuja's sampradaya: in 1898 he conversed in Kashi with Rama Mishra Shastri, read books in four South Indian languages, wrote in the “Sajjana-toshani” about Sri Nathamuni, Yamunacharya and other acharyas, and at Perumbudur learned from a tridandi of this line the rules of Vaishnava tridanda-sannyasa. He was the first who gathered and spread the literature of the Pancharatra, which Ramanuja's line follows in all its rites, and he introduced pancharatrika diksha; he also collected the books of Ramanuja's line — the “Sri-bhashya,” the “Prapannamrita” and others — and published more than two hundred books on the scriptures of the Gosvamis and on the sampradayas of Sri Madhva and of Sri.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta planned the temple of the Chaitanya Math so that at its corners would stand images of the acharyas of the four sampradayas, Ramanuja among them; following the example of Shankara, Ramanuja, Madhva and Sri Chaitanya he toured all of India preaching, and in 1932 in Madras he held discussions with scholars of the schools of Shankara, Ramanuja and Madhva. A verse glorifying Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura says that even the merits of earlier acharyas such as Ramanuja do not equal his, for he is the very ocean of prema incarnate.

Significance

The verse on Ramanuja's birth calls him the form of Shesha, an incarnation of Ananta; Sri Vaishnavas honour in him Lakshmana, the eternal servant of Rama. He established in the South the worship of Narayana and the path of surrender to the Lord, opening the mantra to all who sought salvation, and left

an interpretation of the Vedanta in which the Lord is a Person, and the world and the souls are His energy.

1. The teacher to whom Ramanuja came first was Kanchipurna, the mantra was given him by Goshthipurna, while the biography names as his teacher Yamunacharya, whom he never met in life.

2. According to another account, Ramanuja began a fast there.

3. According to the biography, it was the tenth day of the dark half of Phalguna.

4. According to two biographies, these were panditas of Ramanuja's sampradaya; according to a third, Ramanandis. The Ramanandis, according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.2132–2133) and the “Anuragavalli” (8.41–42), are a branch of the same line: Ramananda appeared among the followers of Ramanujacharya, and from his disciples the Ramanandi sampradaya arose.